Wheelchair Blues

By James I. Schempp

INTRODUCTION

CHARLOTTE: Being looked at is not being seen.
BARNEY: Looking at someone is not seeing them.
CHARLOTTE: Sympathy is not understanding.
BARNEY: Feeling sorry for someone is not helping them.
BOTH: "Wheelchair Blues"
BARNEY: By James I. Schempp

(CHARLOTTE WHEELER enters in a wheelchair, which she stops at Center Stage. BARNEY LUFTER enters. He opens the doors of the auditorium to make sure they are functioning properly; the sound of the concert washes over the stage. He closes the doors and approaches CHARLOTTE.)

BARNEY: Uh, you're not planning to sit here much longer are you?

CHARLOTTE: How was the concert?

BARNEY: Because that probably won't be a very good place to be in about ... *(Checks his watch)* ten minutes.

CHARLOTTE: I didn't go to the concert because there is a flight of fourteen steps just inside those doors.

BARNEY: The concert will end then and this place is going to be virtually flooded with thousands of wild-eyed teenagers headed for their cars.

CHARLOTTE: They are very pretty stairs. Made out of New Hampshire granite. Did you know that?

BARNEY: *(Nodding his head toward the side of the stage)* You want to come over there with me, we can watch it together. From a safe place.

CHARLOTTE: Fourteen granite steps. *(Pause)* You sure of the ending time?

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BARNEY: Hm?

CHARLOTTE: You know for sure when it's gonna end?

BARNEY: To the minute. This whole concert is planned to the split-second. Gotta be. You ever seen the lighting effects they use? They gotta know exactly where someone's gonna be every second. Now let's get you out of here.

CHARLOTTE: I haven't seen the special effects. I'm not allowed to see them.

BARNEY: That's too bad. Really neat stuff. The concert started three minutes late, so the final encore will end in exactly... *(Consults his watch again)* nine minutes and thirty-five seconds.

CHARLOTTE: That long?

BARNEY: *(Moving behind chair to push it)* It's a big finish, too. The kids get real hyped up and come crashing out of there like a herd of buffalo. So like I said, you better come out of the way or they'll run right over you. *(The chair doesn't move.)* You got the brakes on or what?

CHARLOTTE: It's broken.

BARNEY: 'Cause this thing ain't moving.

CHARLOTTE: I said, it's broken. I broke it.

BARNEY: Yeah? Where's it broken? Maybe I can put it back together.

CHARLOTTE: I don't think so. It's in the axle itself.

BARNEY: Bad news. *(Trying to make it a joke)* Now why'd you go and break your chair in a dangerous place like this? You trying to get yourself killed?

CHARLOTTE: *(Quietly)* Yes.

BARNEY: *(Nervous)* Yes? What d'ya mean, yes? You didn't break the chair intentionally, did you?

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CHARLOTTE: Yes. I did.

BARNEY: Why the hell did you do a thing like that?

CHARLOTTE: *(Her anger welling out of her)* Because I want someone to say, "Gee, I wonder what she was doing there, *because you know she couldn't get into the concert because there is no way to get a wheelchair into that damned auditorium!"*

BARNEY: *(Examining the chair)* Maybe I can fix this.

CHARLOTTE: *(Recovering slightly)* Did you hear what I said?

BARNEY: Huh? Sure. How'd this get broken?

CHARLOTTE: It's easy. You just take a wrench and grab that little tab, then turn it with all your might and the axle gets jammed and there's no way to fix it and there's no way to move it.

BARNEY: Jeez, lady! This is serious!

CHARLOTTE: *(Slowly and with emphasis)* I intentionally disabled my wheelchair. *(Lighter, to herself)* Hey! How about that! Now it's my wheelchair that's handicapped!

BARNEY: I gotta get some help to take care of this. *(The noise of the concert is heard again as BARNEY reaches for his walkie-talkie. CHARLOTTE makes a lunge for it and gets it out of his hand. The effort of this pulls her from her chair and she ends up on the ground. She sits and places the walkie-talkie beneath her.)*

CHARLOTTE: I don't want it taken care of, damn you!

BARNEY: *(Lunging)* Hey, give me that radio!

CHARLOTTE: *(Pulling a can of Mace from her book bag)* Don't touch me!

BARNEY: OK! OK...

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CHARLOTTE: This stuff smells terrible and it hurts worse.

BARNEY: I said, OK!

CHARLOTTE: I'll use it if I have to!

BARNEY: I'm not going to touch you, OK?

CHARLOTTE: Stand over there!

BARNEY: Just take it easy. The last thing we need right now is for me to be blind!

CHARLOTTE: Yeah. One handicap is enough, right?

BARNEY: Huh?

CHARLOTTE: Skip it. Will you *please* go away!

BARNEY: *(At the end of his patience)* Look, lady! I don't know what your problem is, but you are sitting in the path of several thousand people who are going to start coming through those doors in six minutes and fifteen seconds, and they aren't going to see you sitting there, and even if they did, I very much doubt that they will give a care and you could get hurt real bad. Now will you just calm down and let me take you to a more convenient place.

CHARLOTTE: I don't *want* to be taken to a more convenient place! That's the point! *Please go away!*

BARNEY: No, I will not go away. I have a job to do.

CHARLOTTE: Then do it!

BARNEY: That's what I'm trying to do. What are you, some kind of protesting nut?

CHARLOTTE: I am not a protestor. I am not a nut. I am not a "handicapped person." I am Charlotte Wheeler. And I want to be seen. And I want to be recognized as an individual. And if I can't be seen, then I want to do

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something to make people aware of me, even if I have to trip them up to do it.

BARNEY: OK! OK. *I see you!* Now let's move it. I have other things to do, other doors to check.

CHARLOTTE: No you don't.

BARNEY: I don't what?

CHARLOTTE: You don't see me.

BARNEY: Lady, believe me, I see you.

CHARLOTTE: Can you see me riding a merry-go-round? I'm sick of places I can't go and cars I can't drive and pay phones I can't reach and toilets I can't get into and classes I can't take, for God's sake, because I can't get up the stairs to the classroom!

BARNEY: Look, you *have* to get out of the way. In ... *(Looks at his watch)* four minutes and thirty seconds, those doors are gonna open and you're gonna get trashed!

CHARLOTTE: Nothing new. It happens every day.

BARNEY: *(Pause)* So you're upset because you can't ride a merry go-round?

CHARLOTTE: That was just an example.

BARNEY: You're really feeling sorry for yourself, aren't you?

CHARLOTTE: Damned right. No one else will do it for me, so I gotta do it myself. *(Pause)* Look, I was out at the Crossroads Mall this afternoon, and I ...

BARNEY: You what?

CHARLOTTE: Nothing. This is stupid. Will you please leave?

BARNEY: You want to get trampled by a herd of rock fans?

CHARLOTTE: Smart boy! You finally figured that out, did you?

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BARNEY: Why?

CHARLOTTE: Because I can only be overlooked for so long. *(Turning on BARNEY)* Look. *(He averts his eyes.)* No, I mean *look at me!*

BARNEY: If you don't ...

CHARLOTTE: Do you know what happens when I roll down the street? People get out of my way, sometimes they open doors for me, but they're always looking three feet over my head! That's where my face would be if I were standing up. When they bother to notice me at all, they talk to me like I'm an idiot! The world is full of schmucks and I am an invisible person! You don't see me, no one sees me! Tonight, when these people come out of the concert, they are going to trample me. And maybe I'll be hurt. Real bad hurt. *(Pause)* What's the worst thing that could happen to me?

BARNEY: *(Quietly)* You could get killed.

CHARLOTTE: That's not necessarily bad.

BARNEY: You could get maimed! You could end up ...

CHARLOTTE: In a wheelchair? *(BARNEY has nothing to say. He looks at his watch.)*

BARNEY: Two and a half minutes. *(Pause)* You're going to just sit there?

CHARLOTTE: *(Quietly)* Yes. *(Pause)* I can't play hackey-sack! I can't play Frisbee!

BARNEY: "I can't, I can't, I can't!" All you do is whine "I can't!"

CHARLOTTE: I went by the pet store. At the mall. *(Pause)* There was a real cute little Scotty in the window. *(Pause)* I had a dog. She died.

BARNEY: Look...

CHARLOTTE: Pets are great, y'know? I mean, they don't care if you're sitting

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down or standing up. All they want is love, and all they give is love. *(Pause, then going on with increasing intensity)* And all you have to do is take them for a walk and keep them on a leash so they won't run off into the traffic, but if the leash slips and she runs off anyway, there's no way you can stop her if you can't run ... *(She rushes on with the same intensity.)* Have you ever seen me before?

BARNEY: We don't have time for this ...

CHARLOTTE: You're Barney Lufter. You're a junior in college. You are a member of Theta Chi. You work weekends as a security guard and you're studying pre-law. You drive a little red Chevrolet and you park it in the library parking lot. *(BARNEY is taken by surprise, and for the first time, he looks directly at CHARLOTTE.)*

BARNEY: How'd you know all that?

CHARLOTTE: I see you every day. We pass each other all the time between classes. We even had a class together. Intro to Business Law.

BARNEY: Was that you? I didn't recognize you.

CHARLOTTE: Of course you didn't! Until I sat here I was invisible to you. You ignored me.

BARNEY: I wouldn't exactly say I *ignored* you.

CHARLOTTE: That's *exactly* what you did! Three weeks ago ... you probably don't even remember, do you?

BARNEY: Remember what?

CHARLOTTE: Nothing. Nothing! I'm just so ... *(Collects herself)* I made an extra special effort to get your attention three weeks ago. It was a Thursday afternoon. I usually leave campus on a special bus at one o'clock in the

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afternoon on Thursdays, but I made arrangements to stay late because you were going to present a report in Dr. Lee's symposium.

BARNEY: *(Remembering the event)* That's right ...

CHARLOTTE: I went to the seminar room. I waited outside for you. I knew just what I was going to say. I had it all set out, starting from the first word. I wore my best ...When you came up I said "Hi..." You just kept walking by. You didn't even acknowledge my existence! I gave it my best shot, I put all I had into that one word, "Hi..." Everything I *am* was attached to that one word! If you had just picked it up. If you had just *responded!* All of me would have come along with it. That was the opening gambit! Of course you don't remember! Of course you didn't hear! I wasn't there! You just walked past me because I didn't exist! You never saw me. That was the first time I ever tried, I mean really *tried,* to get someone to deal with me on a grown-up, real-person basis. I wanted you to look me in the eyes and treat me like I was something other than a poor idiot child! You could have done so much. But I thought, he's probably thinking about his report. I'll wait until afterwards and try again. So I sat at the back of the room. I hung on every word you said. I gave you all my attention. When you finished, I'm the one who started the applause! You came off the podium and everyone was telling you what a great job you did. When you came past me, you looked right *at* me. I *know* you did. I waited until I could see your eyes, and I said it again. "Hi... " And you ignored me again. you looked right *at* me, but you never saw me!

BARNEY: I don't even remember that.

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CHARLOTTE: That's the point. *(CHARLOTTE stops, bites her lip and stiffens. She cries in spite of herself and tries to keep BARNEY from seeing it. BARNEY considers, then reaches a decision. He sits down beside her.)*

BARNEY: Move over.

CHARLOTTE: Will you please go away! It's too late now!

BARNEY: Nope. You're gonna sit here, I'm gonna sit here.

CHARLOTTE: I don't want you here.

BARNEY: I don't want *you* here!

CHARLOTTE: Why are you trying to take care of me? I don't want you to take care of me. I'm an adult and I can make my own decisions! Now get the hell out of here.

BARNEY: Sorry. If they walk on you, they're gonna have to walk on me too.

CHARLOTTE: You're screwing everything up!

BARNEY: Life is like that sometimes. You get a nice little plan and someone comes along and messes it up. Someone makes you see something or someone refuses to see something or someone gets converted to your point of view. It's a bitch, but it happens.

CHARLOTTE: Why are you doing this?

BARNEY: I'm sharing the experience with you.

CHARLOTTE: Do you know how dumb that sounds?

BARNEY: Sorry.

CHARLOTTE: You might get hurt.

BARNEY: There's a terrific echo around here.

CHARLOTTE: *(After a pause)* Look. You can avoid this. You can just get up and walk. Now will you please do it?

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BARNEY: What's the matter? Can't you take "yes" for an answer?

CHARLOTTE: I...

BARNEY: You win! I'm noticing you! *(BARNEY sits in silence as they consider the situation. CHARLOTTE hands the walkie-talkie back to him.)*

CHARLOTTE: Here's your radio.

BARNEY: Thanks.

CHARLOTTE: You want to use it?

BARNEY: Too late now.

CHARLOTTE: *(Pause)* How much time?

BARNEY: Fifteen seconds.

CHARLOTTE: Are you sure you want to do this?

BARNEY: No. *(There is another slight pause. Then BARNEY turns to CHARLOTTE and looks her directly in the eyes as he extends his hand.)* Hi. *(CHARLOTTE takes his hand and holds it.)*

CHARLOTTE: Hi. *(The sound of a large crowd is heard approaching the closed doors of the auditorium. The sound suddenly increases as if the doors have been opened like floodgates. The lights fade to black with the crowd noise reaching a crescendo.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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